Drug Trafficking
By
Organized Crime Syndicates

What Is Drug Trafficking

Drug trafficking is a global illicit trade involving the cultivation, manufacture, distribution and sale of substances which are subject to drug prohibition laws (United Nations).

- Key Activities
- Cultivation and Production: Growing or making illegal drugs, such as cocaine, heroin, methamphetamine, and fentanyl.
- Transportation and Smuggling: Moving large amounts of illegal substances across local, state, or international borders.
- Distribution and Sale: Supplying drugs to wholesale networks, local dealers, or end users.

Historical Background

•The earliest **"war against drugs"** in the US was in response to opium, an **analgesic** (pain reliever) and central nervous system depressant that can provide relief from stress.

- Before modern medicine, pain relief was a major goal of treatment. Opium was widely used to treat Pain; Diarrhea and dysentery; Asthma; Fever; Insomnia; Rheumatism and other illnesses
- Opiates were widely available in the U.S. until **1914.** Doctors commonly prescribed them for various illnesses. It was often available without prescription.
- Chinese immigrants helped popularize opium smoking in California.
- Commercial **"opium dens"** emerged, sometimes becoming associated with criminal activity.

Historical Background

Rise of Morphine

- Morphine was developed from opium around the beginning of the 19th century.
- It was much more powerful than opium.
- By the 1850s, morphine products were widely available.
- The introduction of the hypodermic syringe (1856) made injection possible.
- Morphine use increased dramatically during the U.S. Civil War.

After the Civil War

- Widespread morphine use among soldiers contributed to what was called "***army disease"- Morphine dependence among veterans.***
- Morphine was: Cheap, Easily available, Frequently prescribed and sometimes misused by doctors and the public
- Addiction was poorly understood.

Historical Background

The Emergence of Heroin

- Around 1900, diacetylmorphine **(heroin)** was synthesized.
- It was initially marketed as a safer, non-addictive alternative to morphine.
- Heroin and other opiates remained widely available in the U.S. until 1914.
- After the widespread medical use, misuse also increased rapidly and people were starting to understand addiction. This gave rise to government regulations.

British–China trade imbalance: Britain used Indian opium to offset its growing demand for Chinese tea. China banned opium, but widespread smuggling and corruption undermined the ban.

- 1839: China confiscated and destroyed British opium that enabled **the First Opium War (1840–42).**
- China was defeated and forced to pay compensation; Hong Kong became a British colony.
- 1856–60: **The Second Opium War** further weakened China and expanded foreign trading privileges.
- The wars demonstrated how drug trade, international commerce, and political power became interconnected.
- Impact on the U.S.: The expanding opium trade also contributed to increased opium availability among Chinese communities in the United States.

Historical Background

- Chinese workers migrated to the U.S. for mining and railroad work.
- Chinese communities became associated with opium smoking, fueling anti-Chinese sentiment.
- 1880s: U.S. began restricting opium imports, particularly targeting Chinese immigrants.
- 1909: International Opium Commission established.
- 1912: International Opium Convention adopted.
- 1914: Harrison Act introduced federal regulation of opiates and cocaine.
- Drug control shifted from racialized restrictions to formal federal and international regulation.

Why Smugglers Do It

1. Huge Profit
Banning a product makes its price skyrocket across borders. Example: Cocaine costs ~$2,000/kg in South America, but sells for up to $200,000/kg in Australia due to tight borders.

2. Dodging High Taxes
High government taxes on legal goods create illegal markets. Example: Smuggling untaxed cigarettes into Europe yields over $8 million per shipping container with lower jail risks than drugs. Smugglers and cartels care **only about money**, not human lives

3. High Demand & Addiction
Addicted buyers will purchase products regardless of cost or law. Example: Cheaply made synthetic meth (Yaba) in Myanmar fuels an estimated $60 billion drug market across East Asia.

4. Weak Borders & Corruption
Routine, low-risk business transactions and huge bribes over low securtiy borders. Example: Hard-to-patrol river borders in Southeast Asia allow gangs to easily move illegal cargo past border posts.

Narcotics Scenario in the Developing and Developed World

Major Drug-Producing Nations

- Many **developing countries** serve as **production zones** for drugs such as:
    - **Opium** (Afghanistan, Myanmar)
    - **Cocaine** (Colombia, Peru, Bolivia)
    - **Cannabis & Hashish** (Morocco, Afghanistan)
    - **Methamphetamine** (Myanmar, Nigeria)

- **Developed World Scenario**
- High Demand and Markets: Wealthier nations drive high consumer demand, fueling massive profits for international trafficking and synthetic drug networks.
- Medicalized Approach: These nations lean more toward public health models, providing access to residential rehab, harm reduction, and opioid substitution therapy.
- Synthetic Shifts: Markets often focus on prescription opioids, synthetic stimulants, and widespread cocaine consumption

- **Developing World Scenario**
- Production and Transit: Many developing nations serve as cultivation hubs (such as opium or coca) or vital trafficking corridors, suffering from localized corruption and cartel violence.
- Punitive Measures: Imprisonment remains standard due to a lack of healthcare infrastructure and financial resources to fund medical treatment programs.
- Stigma: Cultural and moral views often treat substance abuse strictly as a personal moral failing rather than a chronic health disorder

The Global Drug Supply Chain

Drugs are produced in the developing world and **consumed in the developed world**

Smugglers use:

- **Maritime shipping**
- **Airports**
- **Border tunnels**
- **Digital platforms and dark web**

The Global Drug Supply Chain

- Raw Materials: Chemical and biological precursors are sourced globally to build basic intermediate compounds.
- API Manufacturing: Active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) are produced, with a high concentration of manufacturing centered in countries like China and India.
- Formulation: APIs are converted into finished dosage forms like pills, capsules, or liquids at specialized plants.
- Distribution: Logistics networks transport regulated, often temperature-controlled products to wholesalers, hospitals, and pharmacies

Key Objectives of Drug Syndicates

- Profit maximization: Generating immense revenue by controlling the production, trafficking, and distribution of illicit substances.
- Wealth integration: Laundering illicit cash through legitimate businesses, real estate, and offshore accounts to blend it into the global financial system.
- Market expansion: Developing new consumer bases and introducing synthetic drugs to create fresh, highly addictive revenue streams.

- Political and Social Objectives
- Systemic corruption: Bribing, intimidating, or blackmailing law enforcement, customs officials, politicians, and judges to secure operational impunity.
- Territorial control: Establishing governance over specific geographic areas (often called "narco-states" or lawless zones) to operate without government interference.
- Community co-optation: Subsidizing local infrastructure, healthcare, or social services in impoverished areas to buy public loyalty and shield leadership from authorities

Major Drug Trade Syndicates Around the World

Latin America

- **Mexican cartels** (Sinaloa, Jalisco New Generation) dominate the **North American drug trade**
- **Colombian cartels** (formerly Medellín, Cali) are key in **cocaine production**

Major Drug Trade Syndicates Around the World S

Asia

- **Golden Triangle syndicates** (Myanmar, Laos, Thailand)
    - Produce **opium and methamphetamine**
    - Run by **ethnic militias** like the United Wa State Army
- **Triads and Yakuza** involved in trafficking, money laundering, and distribution in **East Asia**

Europe

- **Albanian mafia**, **'Ndrangheta (Italy)**, and **Russian syndicates**
    - Control ports, heroin routes, and cocaine markets
    - Have deep political and financial ties

Drug Production in the Middle East & Central Asia

This region is a **major global producer of opium**, not cocaine.

Afghanistan has been the **largest opium producer in the world**
Heroin made in Afghanistan is trafficked to:

- **Nearby countries**: Iran, Pakistan, Central Asia
- **Other regions**: Europe, Russia, China

The drug flows through **key smuggling routes** to reach these markets.

Countries near Afghanistan have **some of the highest opiate use rates**:

- **Central Asia**: ~320,000 users (0.6% of population aged 15–64)

Who Controls the Trade? Middle East & Central Asia

1. **The Balkan Route:**
   - Starts in Afghanistan → Pakistan → Iran → Turkey → Eastern Europe → Western Europe
   - Some traffickers avoid Turkey by going through **Romania or Ukraine**

2. **Northern Route:**
   - Passes through **Central Asia to Russia and the Baltic States**
3. **Air Routes:**
   - Drugs flown from Pakistan to the **UK, Africa, or North America**
4. **China-India Route:**
   - Heroin moves through Pakistan and Central Asia into **China and India**

Drugs Often Stay in the Region: Middle East & Central Asia

Drugs don't always reach Western markets.
Many are **diverted to local markets** in:

- **Tajikistan**
- **Kazakhstan**
- **Kyrgyzstan**

This shows the **lack of centralized control** over the trade. This region produces **large amounts of cannabis resin** (a form of hashish). Cannabis resin is **more popular here than cannabis herb**.
Major cultivation areas:

- **Afghanistan**
- **Morocco**

Resin is **trafficked internationally**, mostly to **European markets**.

Drug Trafficking Routes in East & Southeast Asia

9 major drug-trafficking routes run through the region.

4 routes originate in Burma, the main source of narcotics.
Key trafficking paths:

- **Burma → Laos → Cambodia → Thailand**
- **Burma → Thailand → Malaysia, Singapore, Indonesia, Brunei**
- **Burma → India/Bangladesh** (less frequent)
- **Burma → Yunnan, China → Japan, Taiwan, Philippines**

Other routes link:

- **Cambodia/Laos → Thailand → Malaysia/South Korea/Taiwan**

Some drugs also enter the region from Turkey and Iran

Opium Market in the Region in East & Southeast Asia

- Like Central Asia, **opium is the main drug produced**.
- **Most opium stays within the region** rather than being exported.
- **Burma** remains the largest opium grower here.
- **Golden Triangle** (Burma-Laos-Thailand) is the key production area.
- Production in Burma is often run by **ethnic rebel groups** like: **United Wa State Army, Shan State Army-South**
- These groups operate with **military and political influence** in drug zones

Why Afghanistan Matters in Global Drug Trade

For decades, **insurgent and terrorist groups** used drug profits to fund wars.

This began during the **Cold War** and continues today.

Opium has been grown for centuries, but **Afghanistan's key role grew after the 1970s**.

Why?

- **Iran, Pakistan, and Turkey** banned opium
- Traffickers turned to **Afghan farmers**

The **Taliban briefly banned opium in 2001**, but after they were removed, the trade came back strong.

- Massive Decline in Opium Cultivation
- The Taliban's enforcement of the ban has led to a historic 95% drop in opium poppy cultivation compared to pre-ban 2022 levels.
- The Numbers: Total land dedicated to poppy cultivation fell from 232,000 hectares in 2022 down to just 10,200 hectares. Annual opium production plummeted from 6,200 metric tons to roughly 296 tons.
- Regional Shifts: While traditional southwest strongholds have largely stopped cultivation, small-scale farming has shifted toward remote, mountainous northeastern areas like Badakhshan, sometimes leading to violent clashes between local farmers and Taliban eradication teams
- (Ariana News, BBC)

- **Methamphetamine:** Meth production is booming in Afghanistan. It is highly profitable, more covert, more resilient to severe regional droughts, and relies on the native wild Ephedra plant or cheap chemicals rather than vast agricultural fields.
- **Global Threat:** The UN warns that as Afghan heroin stockpiles fully run dry toward the end of 2026, international trafficking networks are rapidly switching to incredibly potent synthetic opioids like fentanyl and nitazenes to fulfill demand, driving up the threat of global overdose crises

Drug Trafficking Routes Out of Afghanistan

Most opium is **exported** to:

- **Europe, Russia, China**

3 major smuggling routes:

1. **To Pakistan** (160 metric tons in 2009)
2. **To Iran** (145 metric tons) → then to Europe via **Turkey**
3. **North to Central Asia** → 75 metric tons to **Russia**

Drugs even reach **Canada, Australia, and East Asia**

Why Burma (Myanmar) Is Important in the Drug Trade

Burma is one of the top 3 drug-producing countries in the world.

Joins **Venezuela and Bolivia** in **failing to meet international anti-drug obligations.**

Poverty is **widespread**:

- ⅓ of population lives **below the poverty line**
- Most people work in **agriculture**
- Only **34%** of people live in cities

Ethnic conflict in areas like **Shan, Wa, and Kachin States** means the **government has little control**, allowing drug trade to thrive.

Drug Trade History in Burma

Began under **British rule**—opium was sold widely

Hill tribes in Shan State kept supplying opium even when other regions were restricted

After **World War II**, Chinese **Kuomintang** forces took over opium trade to fund their fight against communists

Today: Burma is a key player in both **opium** and **synthetic drug production**

Burma's Methamphetamine Boom

- As opium fell, **meth production grew rapidly**
- **Burma is the main source of meth tablets** in the region
- Large-scale **"super labs"** mostly in **Shan State**
- Traffickers operate **freely** in **ungoverned areas**
- Precursor chemicals now include **liquid pharmaceuticals**, not just ephedrine

- Production and Scale
- Opium Surge: Myanmar surpassed Afghanistan as the top global opium producer following the Taliban's cultivation ban. Cultivation reached over **53, 000 hectares.**
- Synthetic Drugs: The Golden Triangle region **(where Shan State meets Laos and Thailand) remains a massive global hub** for manufacturing synthetic drugs like methamphetamine ("ice") and yaba pills.
- Civil Conflict Impact: Ongoing civil war and the breakdown of central governance allow armed factions and criminal networks to expand narcotics production with little interference.

- In recent decades, the country has become a major producer of yaba, a synthetic drug distributed in pills easily available throughout the country.
- Rakhine State has now been transformed into one of the major hubs for drug transit in the country
- Since the Burmese military (Tatmadaw) seized power under a coup in February 2022, drug production in Myanmar has increased
- Shan State, inhabited by Indigenous Shan, Wa, Palaung, Lahu and Akha has a long history of being one of the world's opium (and heroin) repositories
- Traffickers moving drugs either into Bangladesh or Rakhine State are sometimes caught by Tatmadaw officials operating border checkpoints.

Where the Drugs Go (Trafficking Routes)

Drugs are **exported** to:

- **China, Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, Oceania (e.g., Australia)**

Heroin mostly smuggled overland, especially via the **Mekong River**

Airports and ports (e.g., **Rangoon**) are also used

Meth is trafficked to:

- **China (Yunnan Province)**
- **Thailand**

Who Controls the Trade?

Armed insurgent groups run the drug business in their territories:

- **United Wa State Army**
- **Shan State Army**
- **Kachin Independence Army**

Ethnic Chinese crime networks are also involved

These groups **protect and fund their operations** with drug profits

Global Drug Trafficking Routes

1. The Southern Route: Afghanistan - Pakistan (opium)
2. Andean Region: North America - EU (cocaine)
3. The Balkan Route: Afghanistan - Iran - Turkey - Southeast Europe - Western Europe (Heroine)
4. The Northern Route: Afghanistan - Central Asia - Russia - Western Europe (Heroine)

- ***The Andean-North American Route:*** Carries cocaine from South America through Central America and Mexico into the United States and Canada.

Top Ten

Mexico: A dominant source and primary transit route for smuggling synthetic drugs (like fentanyl and methamphetamine) and heroin into North America.

Colombia: One of the world's largest cultivators of coca leaf and producers of cocaine, managing vast trafficking networks toward North America and Europe.

Afghanistan: Historically the world's leading producer of illicit opium and heroin, heavily sustaining regional and international trafficking routes.

Myanmar (Burma): A major center for opium and heroin production in Southeast Asia, alongside massive synthetic methamphetamine manufacturing.

Peru: A top global cultivator of coca and producer of cocaine base, supplying international markets via Pacific and overland routes.

Bolivia: A primary cultivator of coca leaf and producer of cocaine, functioning as a key regional supply node.

Ecuador: A major transit hub where cartels move vast quantities of cocaine from neighboring Andean nations through coastal ports.

Honduras: A vital Central American transit corridor for cocaine moving northward toward the United States.

Nigeria: A central West African node and transit point for international trafficking networks moving cannabis, heroin, and synthetic narcotics.

The Netherlands: A primary European entry point for cocaine and a major manufacturing hub for synthetic drugs distributed across the continent.

Though estimates vary, the illicit drug trade generates hundreds of billions of dollars per year.

Criminal groups innovate constantly, through boosting production, finding new ways to chemically conceal their drugs, and using technology to conceal communications and increase distribution. (UNODC, 2025)



International Drug Cartels (recognized by U.S. Department of State)

- **TdA** is a transnational organization that originated in Venezuela with cells in Colombia, Peru, and Chile.
- **MS-13** is a transnational organization that originated in Los Angeles but shifted to Central America as individuals were deported there from the United States.
- **Cártel de Sinaloa** is a transnational organization based in Sinaloa, Mexico. It is one of the world's most powerful drug cartels and is one of the largest producers and traffickers of **fentanyl** and other illicit drugs to the United States.
- **CJNG** is a transnational organization with a presence in nearly every part of Mexico. Notorious for trafficking fentanyl.

Golden Triangle and Bangladesh

The Golden Triangle: Southeast Asia's Drug Factory

1. What is the Golden Triangle?

- Region where the borders of **Myanmar, Laos, and Thailand** meet.
- Famous for its **massive opium production** historically, now shifting toward **methamphetamine**.

2. Main Drugs Produced

- **Opium → Heroin** (from poppy cultivation)
- **Methamphetamine tablets** (known as *yaba* in South Asia)
- **Cannabis resin** (in smaller quantities)

Golden Triangle and Bangladesh

Interlinked Regional Drug Dynamics

- The **Golden Triangle** — covering parts of **Myanmar (Burma)**, **Laos**, and **Thailand** — is one of the **world's oldest and largest drug-producing regions.**
- **Bangladesh**, though not a major producer, has become a **critical transit and destination country** for narcotics smuggled out of the Golden Triangle.
- Both regions are **strategically and geopolitically important** in understanding **Southeast Asia's narcotics network.**

Golden Crescent

- Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran belong to the 'Golden Crescent' also famous for producing several types of **narcotics**
- Afghanistan has been untested in smuggling drugs to the European countries since 1905
- The land of energy-rich Iran is used as the main route of drugs smuggling into Europe from Asia
- Afghanistan (the primary cultivation hub)

Pakistan (major transit zone and refining hub)

Iran (primary transit corridor toward Europe)

Golden Village

- 26-village of Kushtia district in Bangladesh, better known as ‘Golden Village‘, is also famous for producing **cannabis**
- Bangladesh lies in between drug producing Golden Triangle and Crescent
- Bangladesh are surrounded by Indian and Myanmar hills and mountains. Drug peddlers taking the advantages, turned the hilly borders as major transit points of smuggling.
- Using the Bangladesh transit, drug peddlers have been smuggling narcotics to northern America, Africa and Europe through Dhaka, Chittagong, Cumilla, Khulna and other parts of the country.

Golden Wedge

- The Golden Wedge is perhaps the newest route, linking north Bangladesh to the Indian states of Himachal Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh
- It expands to encompass Nepal and certain parts of Bhutan
- This strategic location means drug gangs from other countries are also active in Bangladesh, including from Sri Lanka and some African countries, and are trying to find easy routes to smuggle their product.
- The Golden Wedge is positioned between Asia's two largest illicit drug manufacturing zones: the Golden Crescent and the Golden Triangle.

Bangladesh: A Growing Drug Hub

Not a Producer, But a Key Transit Point

- **Bordering Myanmar**, Bangladesh has become a **prime route** for **smuggling Golden Triangle drugs** — especially meth (yaba).
- The **Cox's Bazar-Teknaf border**, near the **Rohingya refugee camps**, is the **main smuggling corridor**.

Most Common Drug in Bangladesh

- **Yaba (methamphetamine + caffeine tablets)**
  - Cheap, addictive, and widespread among **youth, workers, and students**
- Also trafficked: **Heroin**, **Phensedyl** (cough syrup with codeine, from India), **cannabis**, and **synthetic drugs**

Cross-Border Smuggling Networks

How Drugs Move

- **Myanmar → Cox's Bazar (Bangladesh)** by:
  - Boat across the **Naf River**
  - Hidden on **human carriers (mules)**
  - Via **Rohingya refugee networks** (exploited by traffickers)
- From Bangladesh:
  - Yaba moves to **Dhaka**, **Chittagong**, and **Sylhet**
  - Distributed to **India and beyond**

In Bangladesh

- Recent nationwide studies by the *Department of Narcotics Control (DNC)* reveal that approximately ***8.2 million people use illegal drugs*** in Bangladesh (nearly 5% of the total population), with the highest concentration of users located in the ***Dhaka division***
- Traffickers exploit at least **105 active or vulnerable border points across 18 districts** to funnel narcotics into the country, utilizing land, riverine, and coastal corridors

Smuggling Routes & Entry Points

- **The Myanmar Corridor:** The southeastern border—including **Teknaf, Ukhiya, and Saint Martin's Island—**remains the primary gateway for synthetic stimulants. Traffickers frequently employ Rohingya-linked carriers to transport cargo across the border.
- **The Indian Corridor:** Spanning eastern, western, and northern borders (such as **Satkhira, Jashore, Cumilla, and Kurigram**), these routes are heavily utilized for smuggling traditional substances.
- **International Transit Hubs:** International syndicates utilize Dhaka Airport as a transit point to move high-value narcotics (like cocaine) from African and South American nations into neighboring India

Drug Type	Primary Source	Market Notes
Yaba & Crystal Meth	Myanmar	Accounts for the **largest share of total drug seizures** in Bangladesh. Consistently targeted by maritime forces.
Cannabis (Weed)	India / Local	The **most widely consumed** substance, used by an estimated 6.1 million individuals.
Phensedyl & Heroin	India	Frequently smuggled across porous land borders via diverse distribution networks.
New Psychoactive Substances (NPS)	International	Emerging threats include **LSD (lysergic acid diethylamide), MDMA**(Methylenedioxymethamphetamine), and the unauthorized online sale of precursor chemicals

Evolving Methods

- Digital Networks: The illicit trade has heavily shifted to social media, encrypted messaging apps, and digital payment systems to obscure transactions.
- Vulnerable Carriers: PLOS ONE highlight the growing use of women and children under 15 as couriers, often driven by socioeconomic coercion or severe poverty.
- Urban Hotspots: Major distribution operations rely on highly dense municipal zones, such as Geneva Camp in Dhaka, where high population density allows ringleaders to mask their activities.

- **Illicit Capital Flight:** According to data from the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD), Bangladesh loses roughly **USD 481 million annually** to drug trafficking, ranking 5th globally for money laundering tied to the narcotics trade.

THANK YOU

- https://www.iwgia.org/en/news/myanmar-the-drug-epidemic-in-rakhine-state?lang=en